than abiding by civil and criminal law.'[30] It must at the same time be kept in mind that if the emperor was merely reminding people in a general way about the path of morality as defined by age-old tradition, it may have been because the generality of the message was at the time of its transmission supplemented or accompanied by further instructions pertaining to the specific area where it had been sent. So, this may well have been the way in which this message was understood in the Chitradurga area of Karnataka, where the cluster of three sites mentioned earlier—Jatinga-Rameshwara, Siddapura, and Brahmagiri—bears practically this same message in this very form. But the brevity and consequent generality seems to have been because the engravers omitted all reference to Ashoka's administrative instructions which had originally accompanied his message. What makes this second message seem rather too broad based and humane is those absent instructions. On the rocks of Erragudi and Rajula-Mandagiri, as also at Nittur, stern orders accompanied the message. Whether Ashoka's orders were meant to be inscribed or propagated orally has been debated, but once inscribed could be imperious and authoritative;[31] in fact they were very considerably at variance with the softly focused universal virtues.

The message in the latter places bristles with directions. The emperor expected that the governor 'should pass orders in the words of the Beloved of the Gods' and that his mahamatras pass orders about the necessity of obeying the morality expounded by him to the 'rajukka'.[32] The mahamatras were officials based in cities, while in the country areas the crucial administrative functionaries were the rajukkas.[33] They, in turn would 'order' the people of the countryside, as well as a class of officials called 'rashtrikas'—governors of parts of a district. Additionally, the orders were expected by the emperor to be passed on to elephant-riders, scribes, charioteers, and Brahman teachers. Pupils too had to be instructed in accordance with ancient tradition or 'porana pakiti'. Ancient tradition figured on more than one occasion in the instructions, with Ashoka